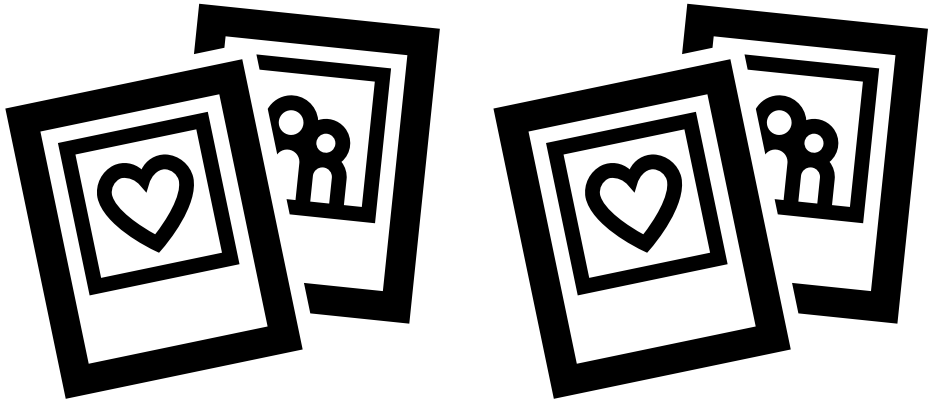


Racial & Ethnic Identity Experiences

THE SELF & SOCIAL IDENTITIES

RACE, IDENTITY, AND APPEARANCE DON'T ALWAYS MATCH





Caregiver/Upbringing Perspectives

Is not talking about race actually a form of racial socialization?

What is the difference between teaching children to “treat everyone the same” and teaching them to understand how race affects how people are treated?

When does cultural socialization count as talking about race or ethnicity—even if nobody explicitly labels it that way?

How does a caregiver’s own childhood experience shape what they teach/avoid race?

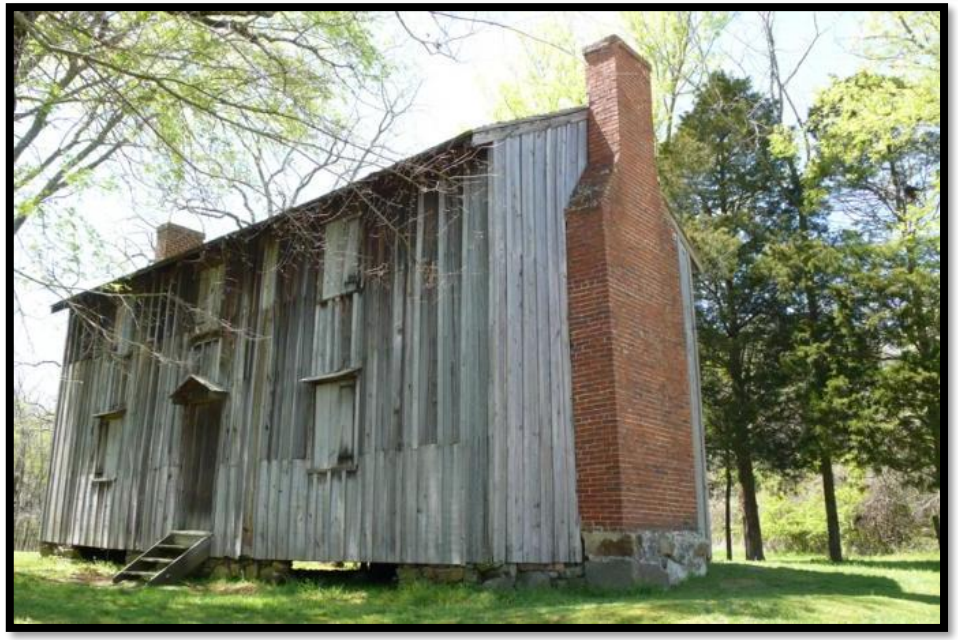
How much should parents follow children's questions versus proactively initiate conversations about race?

American Girl Doll Addy Walker from Durham!



The fictional story of Addy Walker is based on a real person who lived in Durham at the Historic Stagville Plantation in the 1800s.

Addy's story comes partially from the life of Mary Walker, who escaped from Stagville's owners in 1848, according to the N.C. Department of Natural and Cultural Resources.



Stagville is home to one of the largest plantations in Antebellum North Carolina.



Representation Shapes Career Identities







Representation Shapes Aspirations





Racial Identity vs. Ethnic Identity

Racial Identity: A socially constructed system of classifying individuals according to phenotypical/physical characteristics that usually result from genetic ancestry (but not always)

Ethnic Identity: people who identify with each other on the basis of common nationality or shared cultural traditions or history (place of birth, racial, religious, linguistic…)



Racial Identity Development

1) Pre-encounter: You are not yet consciously aware of race and its significance

2)Encounter: You have an experience that causes you to reassess yourself along racial lines or characteristics

3) Immersion: You begin to directly explore your own racial background

4) Internalization & Commitment: You commit to a particular racial identification and adopt related traits, perspectives and traits (but there is individual variability here)

Children Also Learn from Nonverbal Cues

WHAT CHILDREN OBSERVE



Who parents smile at and show warmth toward



Who parents sit near, include, or spend time with



Body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice



Friendships and people they trust



Comfort (or discomfort) during interactions with people from different racial groups

What is ethnic identity to a kid?

"[Being Russian] means to be from a different country, have different personalities, and speak a different language."
—Russian American boy, fourth grade

"[Being Dominican means] to talk in Spanish, eat different kinds of food and wear different clothes that Americans don't."
—Dominican American boy, second grade

"[Being White means] like, people are born black and white. A long time ago White people used to do whatever they want. And we have to learn that we're all the same."
—White American girl, fourth grade

Rogers ethnic identity study

Research Question:

- Does an understanding of the meaning of ethnic identity emerge in middle childhood and are there age and ethnic group differences?

Method: 403 children in the second and fourth grades in NYC (228 girls; 24% Chinese American, 25% Dominican American; 18% Russian American; 22% White; and 11% Black

Completed an interview session about the meaning of the child's ethnic identity and responses were coded

Rogers study: What Responses Stand Out?

Table 1—page 102

Physical Appearance: "My skin color, my hair—different color people have curly hair" (Black girl, fourth grade)

Power: "You don't get bossed around as much as Black people" (White girl, fourth grade)

Socioeconomic status: "It means to be poor and not speak English." (Dominican American boy, second grade)

Pride: "It means you are special since you learn another language" (Chinese American boy, fourth grade)

Positive traits: "Dominicans are hardworking, responsible, take care of themselves" (Dominican American boy, fourth grade)

Rogers ethnic identity study

Main Results:

- Middle childhood is an active period for ethnic identity content development
- Very few age differences
- But a lot of variability in the meaning of ethnic identity across ethnic groups





Ethnic identity discussion

Language was coded as one of the most popular responses for children. Is language the strongest feature for ethnicity? Thoughts?

How much does ethnic identity vs. racial identity play in intergroup conflict? Is one more malleable than the other?



Rhodes (2013): How Two Intuitive Theories Shape Social Categorization

How do children decide which social categories are meaningful?

Children map intuitive theories about how the social world works onto categories they encounter.

The same category can be understood differently depending on children's experiences and cultural input.

Theory 1: Social categories as natural kinds



Some categories are viewed as stable, objective, biologically based, and informative about group members.

Young children recognize racial categories but do not initially treat race as a natural kind.

Essentialist beliefs about race develop later and vary across cultural contexts compared to categories like gender.

Theory 2: Social categories as markers of social obligations

Children may use categories to make social predictions even when they do not view the categories as biologically real.

Generic language (“boys like trucks”) encourages children to see categories as reflecting stable kinds.

Experiences with diversity can make children’s category beliefs more flexible.





Discussion Questions

What is the difference between recognizing a category and believing that it reflects a real, stable kind of person?

If children naturally use categories to organize the social world, is the goal to eliminate categorization—or to teach children how to use categories more flexibly and critically?



Describe This Scene



Describe This Scene

Partner A: Use no labels or groups/kinds



Describe This Scene

Partner B: Use any label or category



What information became difficult or impossible to communicate without categories?

What did categories help you notice, predict, or remember?

What did categories cause you to assume about people?

Did avoiding categories reduce stereotyping?



What does Adichie mean by a “single story,” and how does one develop?

Why are single stories often based on partial truths rather than complete fabrications?

Is it possible to avoid single stories entirely, or is the goal to hold multiple stories at once?

COFFEE HOUR TODAY 3:30PM OUTSIDE OF PANERA!



Next Class…

Multiracial Identity Thursday!

Paper 1 Due Thursday 9/24!